

HOLLOW MANOR, PART II

THE WORKS-ON-MY-MACHINE MURDER

A Flox mystery in three clues

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COLD OPEN

IT WORKED ON THAT MACHINE.

On mine, the manor stays dark.

```
$ python3 server.py
⚠️  RUNPOD_API_KEY is not set; the manor will stay dark…
```

MEET THE DETECTIVE

A FLOX ENVIRONMENT IS ONE FILE.

The *tools*, the *settings*, and the *services* a project needs.

Every machine that activates it gets the same thing.

HOW IT FEELS

YOUR MACHINE, PLUS THE PROJECT.

Hollow Manor's tools & settings	`flox activate`
Your shell, editor, dotfiles	unchanged
Your OS: macOS or Linux	unchanged

No container to build.

No VM.

Leave the project, and the layer goes with you.

CLUE 1

TWO PYTHONS. THREE WITNESSES.

THE README

"3.9+"

Any Python will do, apparently.

THE DOCKERFILE

3.12

`FROM python:3.12-slim`

MY LAPTOP

¯_(ツ)_/¯

Whatever it shipped with.

```
$ flox init
$ flox install python312
$ flox activate
```

THE EVIDENCE

WHAT YOU ASKED FOR. WHAT YOU GOT.

.FLOX/ENV/MANIFEST.TOML

```
[install]
python.pkg-path = "python312"
```

You write this.

.FLOX/ENV/MANIFEST.LOCK

```
The exact build of
Python 3.12 for each
system, pinned.
```

Flox writes this.

Commit both.

CLUE 2

THE KEY IN THE SHELL.

```
$ export RUNPOD_API_KEY=rpa_DEMO_not_real
$ history | grep rpa_
  512  export RUNPOD_API_KEY=rpa_DEMO_not_real
```

The README says `export`. Your shell history says forever.

THE RULE

SETTINGS ARE SHARED. SECRETS ARE LOADED.

[VARS]: COMMITTED, SHARED

```
[vars]
PORT = "8666"
DAILY_BUDGET_USD = "2"
```

[HOOK]: READS .ENV, NEVER SHARED

```
[hook]
on-activate = '''
  set -a
  . "$FLOX_ENV_PROJECT/.env"
  set +a
'''
```

A secret never goes in the manifest.

CLUE 3

THE SERVER NOBODY MANAGED.

`python3 server.py` lives and dies with one terminal tab.

```
[services.manor]
command = 'python3 "$FLOX_ENV_PROJECT/server.py"'
```

```
$ flox activate --start-services
$ flox services logs manor --follow
```

THE ACCUSATION

A CLEAN MACHINE. ONE COMMAND.

```
$ git clone https://github.com/justincastilla/hollow-mansion-II.git
$ cd hollow-mansion-II
$ flox activate --start-services
```

No clone at all? `flox push`, then `flox activate -r`.

THE REVEAL

CASE CLOSED.

THE CLUE	THE CULPRIT	THE EVIDENCE
Two Pythons	No pinned toolchain	`flox install` + the lockfile
The key in the shell	Secrets with no home	`[hook]`, with settings in `[vars]`
The foreground process	A server nobody managed	`[services]`
"Works on my machine"	All of the above	`flox activate`

EPILOGUE

THE SUSPECT WAS NEVER THE CODE.

It was everything around it.

flox.dev/docs

github.com/justincastilla/hollow-mansion-II

Next: containers with flox containerize · composing environments with [include]